

Early building materials

Early architects used many different materials, depending on how easily available these were and how long a building needed to last.

Mud

Mud-brick buildings needed constant repair and renewal, and were practical only in areas of low rainfall.



Wood

Although plentiful in forest areas, wood was at high risk of fire and unsuitable for very large constructions.

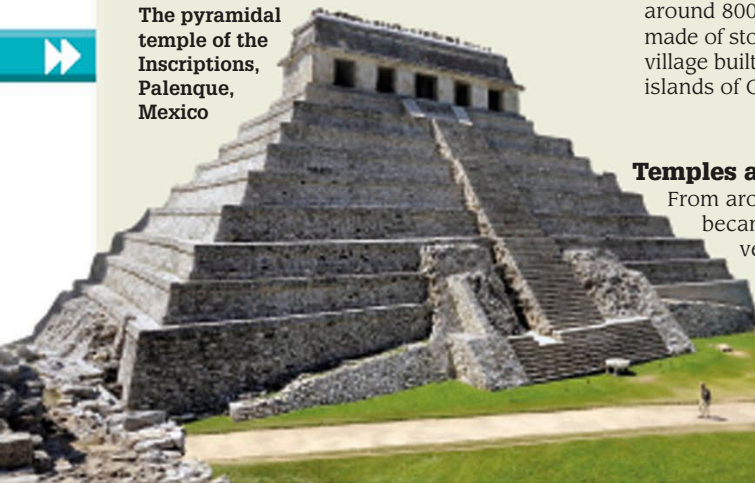


Stone

Stone was a strong and durable material for monumental structures, but its use depended on suitable quarries.



The pyramidal temple of the Inscriptions, Palenque, Mexico



Ancient architecture

Our ancestors made primitive shelters of wood as long ago as 500,000 BCE. From around 9000 BCE, they learned how to erect larger buildings of stone. By 3000 BCE, architecture and engineering had advanced so far that it was possible to create monumental structures such as pyramids, temples, and palaces.



Stone dwelling at Skara Brae

First buildings

Many early towns, such as Çatalhöyük in Turkey (see p.12), had mud-brick houses. Sometimes towns had protective stone walls, such as those of Jericho in Palestine, built around 8000 BCE. Occasionally, houses were made of stone, as at Skara Brae, a Neolithic village built about 3200 BCE on one of the islands of Orkney, Scotland.

Temples and pyramids

From around 3000 BCE, architects became skilled enough to design very large buildings. They knew how to provide massive support at the base of pyramids, which were common in Egypt and Central America. Another skill was building columns that held up the roof of a large temple while leaving usable space beneath.

The outer wall is made of travertine, a type of limestone, while the inner wall is made of concrete.



Key events

10,000 BCE

Hilltop temple at Göbekli Tepe, Turkey, was constructed. It is the oldest-known large-scale stone building.

c 2575 BCE

The Great Pyramid of Giza, Egypt, was built as a tomb for Pharaoh Khufu. It was the largest building in the ancient world, containing 92 million cubic feet (2.6 million cubic meters) of stone.

438 BCE

Built in Athens, the Parthenon was a temple to the Greek goddess Athena, built mainly in the Doric style (a traditional column design). It was regarded as one of the finest works of Greek architecture.

Parthenon, Greece

